

SKILL TRAINING UNDER NATIONAL SKILL QUALIFICATION FRAMEWORKS (NSQF) IN INDIA: A SUSTAINABLE EDUCATIONAL REFORMS

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Abstract

Everything in the corporate world seems to be integrated, this could help to achieve better triumph. Hence, the economic development of nations demand integration at system of learning and employment. This synergy is possible through National Qualification Frameworks (NQF). In Indian context, it is referred to as National Skills Qualification Frameworks (NSQF). Level descriptors are the integral part of any qualification framework. The learning level of an individual is assessed through this indicator. Nevertheless, NSQF with the help of this indicator, certifies the human resource for certain level of expertise. As a result, the certified human resource could be a right person for certain desired job across the globe. Hence, the human resource could be mobilized across nations. The researcher in this paper bring out the scenario as to how NSQF develops skilled human resource and act as recognised and sustainable educational reforms in India, in the present day of digitization.

Key words:

Qualification Framework, NSQF, HRM, Vocational Education, Skill training.

1. Introduction

“People” act as the core of any business or organisation. People could be anyone: the customers, the managers, the employees, the citizens, so on and so forth. Without people, everything that exist is futile. Networking among the people could make all the efforts fruitfull. In the present competitive era of digitalization, networking plays a vital role towards attaining sustainable development. Everything in the corporate world seems to be integrated, to achieve better triumph. Similarly, the economic development of certain nations demand integration. This synergy is possible through National Qualification Frameworks (NQF). In Indian context, it is referred to as National Skills Qualification Frameworks (NSQF). Level descriptors are the integral part of any qualification framework. The learning level of an individual is assessed through this indicator. Nevertheless,

NSQF with the help of this indicator, certifies the human resource for certain level of expertise. As a result, the certified human resource could be a right person for certain desired job across the globe. Hence, the human resource could be mobilized from one nation to another.

General education and vocational education & training have been operating as separate verticals, with very little interaction between the two. This has led to hesitation amongst the youth in opting for vocational education and training as it is presumed that this avenue would preclude the concerned individual from being able to acquire higher degrees and qualifications. In order to facilitate mobility from vocational to general education, and vice-versa, a qualification framework is needed in India. Hence, the National Skill Qualification Framework (NSQF) was notified. This will help make qualifications more understandable and transparent (NSDA). This paper would describe the NQF in detail, including the underlying history. Also, the authors try to fetch the picture as to how NSQF develops skilled human resource and act as recognised and sustainable educational reforms in India, in the present day of digitization.

2. National Qualification Framework (NQF)

2.1 Qualification Framework and Level descriptors

A **Qualifications Framework** is the structure into which accredited qualifications are placed. This allows learners, training providers and employers to gain information about the broad equivalence of qualifications. For example, a Vocational Qualifications Framework (VQF) helps to create parity of esteem between vocational and academic qualifications. Globally, a framework aims to organise information for coordination perspectives. By setting up a framework, it helps people to make logical decisions and coordinate them from a large perspective (UNESCO and UNICEF, 2013).

Level descriptors are statements that provide a broad indication of learning appropriate to attainment at a particular level, describing the characteristics and context of learning expected at that level. They are designed to support the reviewing of specified learning outcomes and assessment criteria in order to develop particular modules and units and to assign credits at the appropriate level (Vlasceanu et al., 2007).

Within qualifications frameworks, [level] descriptors are general, abstract descriptions of learning outcomes. They serve to create points between national and sectoral qualifications and qualifications frameworks. (Hanf and Rein, 2007).

A recently developed NQF, the German Qualifications Framework (Deutsche Qualifikationsrahmen, DQR), proposes the following relationship between learning outcomes and competences. This relationship is useful in that it resonates with the application of the concepts in other qualifications frameworks, most of which do not necessarily make the relationship explicit (German Qualifications Framework Working Group, 2011).

2.2 Historical overview of Qualification Frameworks

The origin of qualification structures can be traced back to organized education in antique civilizations such as Greece, Sparta, Rome and China. As no specialized career structure existed in these cultures, organized education focused on broad issues of international citizenship, and not on

vocational preparedness, which was achieved mainly through informal apprenticeships. As civilizations developed, the role of social class and caste received more emphasis, and people who displayed certain competences were grouped together. The advantage of having participated in and benefited from education gradually became more visible as civilizations developed. In this respect the Chinese civilization was the most organized, with a series of levels attached to examinations, which in turn granted the right of access to public office.

During the Middle Ages education had a particularly religious nature, while the late medieval centuries were categorized by a new approach to education alongside the clergy and feudal knighthood. New economic objectives as a result of the Crusades and the development of banking, importing and shipping across Europe and the West gave rise to the development of cities, and a new form of education aimed at professional life. Education became available to the middle classes, and the merchant and craft guild system developed (Villiers, 1997; Keevy and Chakroun 2015).

The first institutions of formal higher education were established at this time in the Islamic universities of Al-Azhar in Cairo and Sankore in Timbuktu (Serpell, 2007). During the late 1980s, and strongly influenced by the thinking on integration but also by a focus on vocational training through a competency approach, the notion of a National Qualification Frameworks (NQF) emerged in the United Kingdom. Its roots lay in the competence approach to vocational education (Jessup, 1991).

The idea developed that all qualifications could be expressed in terms of outcomes without prescribing learning pathways or programmes (Young, 2005). In the case of France, the NQF drew on a hierarchy of qualifications that found official expression at the end of 1960s in a nomenclature which tried to rationalize the number of students leaving the education and training system to correspond with the needs of the labour market (Keevy and Chakroun 2015).

Across the first-generation countries, NQFs were conceptualized as hierarchical classifications of levels of formal learning programmes and their associated qualifications and certificates (Coles, 2014).

3. Literature Review

The literature includes the countries that have already adopted NQF model in their respective nations. The following are some of the studies carried out in various nations:

South Korea (96%): South Korea provides a neat illustration of a developing economy reaping the benefits of a concerted strategy. South Korea underwent reforms in the 1990s in order to ensure a mass supply of skilled workers to the industry and protect vulnerable groups of the population from unemployment. South Korea's job skill development program, under the framework of the employment insurance system, expanded the existing levy-grant system, where employers received a rebate for training existing employees. This led to an increase of over 27% in training participation by employees and the number of employees trained by employers increased by almost 13 times (MoHUPA).

Germany (75%): Germany's dual system of vocational education integrates work-based and school-based learning to prepare apprentices for a successful transition to full-time employment. This training would ideally last two to three and a half years, depending on one's occupation. Each week,

trainees spend one or two days in a vocational school and three or four days in their company. Progress is evaluated through final examinations in which trainees must show that they have acquired the necessary skills, and practical and theoretical knowledge from their companies and that they have mastered the course material. The aim of training in the dual system is to provide a broad-based basic to advanced vocational training and impart the skills and knowledge necessary to practice a skilled occupation within a structured course of training. The key success factor for the German system is the added focus on apprenticeship (Federal Ministry of Education and Research, 2003).

United Kingdom (68%): The National Vocational Qualifications (NVQs) were created in response for the felt need for qualifications to be made flexible but rigorous and nationally recognized. NVQs are also part of ‘Modern Apprenticeships’ which are funded through work-based learning. At the industry level, Sector Skills Councils (SSCs) have been licensed and social partners are also engaged. SSCs are tasked with drawing up occupational standards for their sector that will feed into the national reform of qualifications. The Government expects each SSC to draw up a Sector Skills Agreement, in which employers and unions identify skills and productivity needs in their sector and the necessary actions to meet those needs (MoHUPA).

China (47%): China’s VET (Vocational Education & Training) includes pre-employment training, apprenticeship training, on-the-job training and re-training for laid-off workers. It is conducted through government employment training centers, enterprise-sponsored training centers, and non-governmental vocational training organizations. Chinese government has also launched specific initiatives at the local government-level to train unskilled and uneducated migrant labour for sectors like construction (Che Weimin, Dec 2009).

4. Skill Training in India under NSQF: A Sustainable Educational Reforms

The component that could help HRM for synergizing is ‘skill’. The OECD Skills Strategy (OECD, 2012) considers skills as ‘the new global currency’. In the Strategy, ‘skill’ and ‘competence’ are used interchangeably, and collectively defined as: The bundle of knowledge, attributes and capacities that can be learned and that enable individuals to successfully and consistently perform an activity or task and can be built upon and extended through learning. (OECD, 2012a)

The Brussels deliberations concluded that the mobility of people (both learners and workers, including migrant workers) and jobs (including outsourcing and offshoring) constitutes an important driver for the world reference levels (Chakroun, 2013) emanating from the Shanghai Consensus Recommendation (UNESCO, 2012).

India is destined to be a contributor to the global workforce pool on account of demographic bonus, with the growth rate of higher working age population as compared to its total population and home to the second largest population (with a headcount of around 1.4 billion by 2025) in the world with distinct advantage of having the youngest population with an average age of 29 years as against the average age of 37 years in China and the US and 45 years in Western Europe (FICCI, 2014).

Several other reports (CEDEFOP, 2009c; ILO, 2011; OECD, 2010a) also emphasize that specific skills profiles for working in the green economy are necessary. Examples of these are knowledge of sustainable materials, relevant traditional skills, carbon footprinting skills, environmental impact assessment skills and a sound understanding of the sciences and the social and

economic contexts in which they are applied (CEDEFOP, 2009c). The skills required are those necessary for improving energy and resource efficiency, complying with environmental legislation, and reducing environmental pollution and waste (see ILO, 2011).

The entire idea of synergizing HRM through NSQF for sustainable and progressive shift across the world could be brought out only through measuring the level of qualification an individual possesses. For this, it is very crucial to know regarding the assessment of knowledge and placing them at various levels of qualification.

4.1 Specific outcomes expected from implementation of NSQF are:

- Mobility between vocational and general education by alignment of degrees with NSQF.
- Recognition of Prior Learning (RPL), allowing transition from non-formal to organised job market.
- Standardised, consistent, nationally acceptable outcomes of training across the country through a national quality assurance framework.
- Global mobility of skilled workforce from India, through international equivalence of NSQF.
- Mapping of progression pathways within sectors and cross-sectorally.
- Approval of NOS/QPs as national standards for skill training.

A typical NQF consists of 10 levels, where in each level has some defined qualification. The individual is assessed and certified accordingly based on the prior learning test. Before the level is assigned, assessment has to take place. It should seek to answer questions such as (see Hunt et al., 2009):

- Are the differences in (targeted or achieved) learning outcomes so substantial that the foreign qualification cannot be fully recognized? If so, is it possible to grant alternative or partial recognition?
- Are the differences in the further activities for which the foreign and the home country qualifications prepare so substantial that full recognition is not possible? If so, is alternative or partial recognition possible?
- Are the differences in key elements of the programme leading to the qualification so substantial in relation to similar programmes in the host country that full recognition cannot be granted in view of the purpose for which recognition is sought? If so, is alternative or partial recognition possible?
- Is the quality of the programme or the institution at which the qualification was earned so different from similar programmes or institutions in the host country that full recognition is not possible? If so, is alternative or partial recognition possible?

The referencing of qualification frameworks represents a critically important point of development (see Hart, 2009), as it entails practical application of models that up to that point may have remained abstract and amorphous. Since, the assessment decides the level of knowledge, the qualification is identified by the indicator. accordingly, the Human Resource can be placed in any country with this certification and be the right person for a desired position. In this way, HRM can be synergized globally.

5. Conclusion

As the global opportunities expands, the corporate world tend to shrink. The reason could be the network built among various countries. However, the authors in this paper have discussed as to how NQF develops skilled human resource through its objectives, the system of execution and the implementation procedure. Also, the researcher has discussed the way NSQF acts as recognised and sustainable educational reforms in India, in the present day of digitization. The very feature of NQF is that it remains as a strategy in mobility and synerzing the skilled human resource across the globe. Although, in long run, this could be a progressive move and could lead to sustainable growth worldwide.

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